▼ VIEWPOINT

# MILES TO GO

**Modi's expected meeting with Xi at BRICS can't mend the reverses of 2020, unless the border issue is adequately addressed**



BY GAUTAM BAMBAWALE

There is understandable optimism about the recent movement in India-China relations. President Xi Jinping is expected to come to India for the BRICS Summit in mid-September, his first visit here since the Mamallapuram informal summit with Prime Minister Narendra Modi in October 2019. That meeting had come after the Wuhan summit in April 2018 and at a moment when the relationship appeared to have acquired a new strategic stability. Within months, however, it crashed spectacularly with China's military moves in Eastern Ladakh in 2020.

That history must temper our expectations. My assessment is that what happened in Eastern Ladakh took India-China relations 10 steps backwards. Since 2024, we may have moved barely two or three steps forward. We are well behind where the relationship stood in 2019. Rebuilding trust and confidence will require time, effort and political capital on both sides. This does not mean India should stop engaging China.

The recent meeting in Beijing between National Security Advisor Ajit Doval and Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi, the two Special Representatives on the boundary question, is therefore welcome. Their eight-point consensus provides a roadmap, including the two sides reaffirming the importance of peace and tranquility on the border and negotiations towards a fair and mutually acceptable boundary settlement. They agreed to advance work on boundary delimitation and border management, including an "early and substantial harvest", apart from expanding cooperation on border trade and pilgrimage.

These are useful steps. But India needs to be cautious, particularly about the idea of an "early harvest" on the boundary. Historically, India has favoured a comprehensive package settlement covering all sectors. That gives us negotiating leverage: concessions in one sector can be balanced by concessions in another. Settling an easier sector separately could diminish that leverage. There are things we can and should do meanwhile. People-to-people contacts can be rebuilt, visas increased, direct flights expanded. Many of the inter-governmental mechanisms that existed before 2020 have not returned. Economic engagement should be approached pragmatically. If calibrated Chinese investment serves India's national interest, including through a selective relaxation of India's 2020 Press Note 3 placing restrictions on Foreign Direct Investment, there is no reason to reject it simply because it is Chinese.



*Illustration by* RAJ VERMA

**INDIA MUST BE CAUTIOUS ABOUT AN 'EARLY HARVEST' BORDER DEAL WITH CHINA. WE MUST NOT SETTLE EASY SECTORS AND GIVE UP LEVERAGE ON DIFFICULT ONES. BUT WE CAN BE PRAGMATIC ON ECONOMIC ENGAGEMENTS WITH THEM**

But economic policy cannot be made in isolation from strategic policy. China itself does not operate that way. Beijing wants access to the Indian market while remaining reluctant to provide India access to critical technologies in electric vehicles, solar energy and rare-earth magnets. Indian strengths such as pharmaceuticals and software, meanwhile, have made little headway in the Chinese market due to non-tariff barriers.

The structural constraints on the relationship, therefore, remain. One is the unresolved boundary. Another is the China-Pakistan nexus. There is fundamental difference between how Beijing and New Delhi view the border question. China would prefer to compartmentalise it: differences on the boundary should not prevent the rest of the relationship from proceeding normally. India's position must remain steadfast: Peace and tranquility on the border are prerequisites for a normal relationship.

We must understand China's strategic calculus. Its ambition is to build what it calls "comprehensive national power" and eventually challenge the United States for global pre-eminence. Beijing frequently interprets India through the prism of its rivalry with Washington and depicts closer India-US ties as India "siding" with America. India should neither accept that characterisation nor allow China to dictate the terms on which we conduct relationships with other powers.

Xi Jinping's expected visit for BRICS could provide another opportunity to rebuild a relationship badly damaged since his visit seven years ago. But neither a summit nor a series of agreements can erase what happened in 2020. The objective should be a calibrated improvement in relations, but the fundamental principle must remain clear: what happens on the border cannot be separated from what happens in the rest of the relationship. There are still many miles to go. ■

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